

2.6 Imām Zaynul ‘Ābidīn’s Early Years

OBJECTIVES

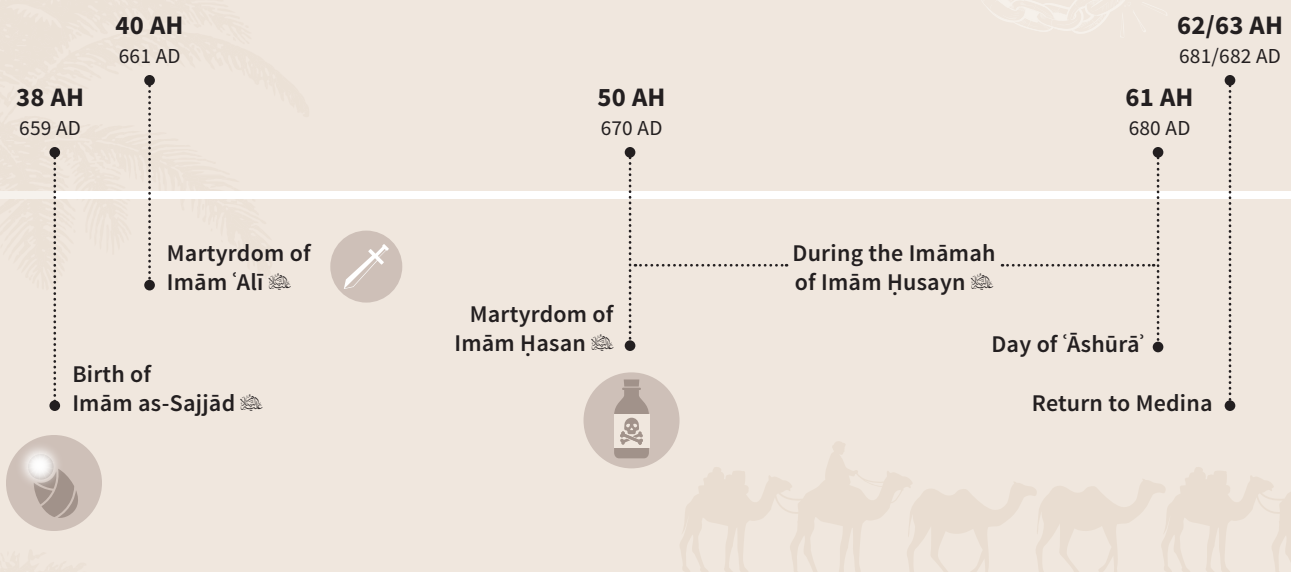
WE WILL:

- Explain how Imām ‘Alī Zaynul ‘Ābidīn as-Sajjād ؑ was named.
- Compare the similarities between Prophet ‘Īsā and Imām as-Sajjād ؑ as babies.
- Review Imām as-Sajjād’s ؑ experiences in the lives of each of the Imāms ؑ prior to him.
- Describe the beautiful worship of Imām as-Sajjād ؑ in his obligatory (*wājib*) and recommended (*mustaḥab*) actions; and then connect this to our own lives.

AN OVERVIEW OF IMĀM AS-SAJJĀD ؑ

Name	‘Alī ibn Ḥusayn ؑ
Kunyah	Abū Muḥammad, Abul Ḥasan
Title	As-Sajjād, Zaynul ‘Ābidīn
Parents	Imām Ḥusayn ؑ and Lady Shahrbanū
Date of Birth	5th of Sha‘bān 38 AH
Birthplace	Kūfah, Iraq (or Medina according to some narrations)
Duration of Imāmah	34 years
Date of Martyrdom	25th of Muḥarram 95 AH
Place of Martyrdom	Medina, Arabia
Cause of Martyrdom	Poisoned by Walīd ibn ‘Abdul Malik
Lifespan	57 years
Location of Grave	Jannatul Baqī in Medina, Arabia

TIMELINE OF IMĀM AS-SAJJĀD ؑ



BIRTH TO SHAHĀDAH OF IMĀM ‘ALĪ ؑ:

5th Sha‘bān 38 AH to the 21st of the month of Ramaḍān, 40 AH (2 years)

Imām ‘Alī as-Sajjād ؑ was born on Thursday, the 5th of Sha‘bān, 38 years after the migration (*Hijrah*). His parents were Imām Ḥusayn ؑ and Lady Shahr-bānū, who was the daughter of a Persian king. The Imām ؑ was born during the period of Imām ‘Alī’s caliphate (*khilāfah*).

It has been narrated from Jābir ibn ‘Abdullāh al-Anṣārī that:

I was sitting with the Messenger of Allah, when he placed al-Ḥusayn on his lap and was playing with him. Then he (the Prophet) said: ‘O Jābir! A son will be born through him, and that son will be named ‘Alī. A caller will call out on the Day of Judgment: ‘Let Sayyid al-‘Ābidīn (the Chief of Worshipers) stand up,’ then, his son will stand up.’¹

When Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was born, his grandfather, Imām ‘Alī ؑ, recited the *adhān* in his right ear and *iqāmah* in his left ear. Seven days after his birth, his father, Imām Ḥusayn ؑ cut his hair, sacrificed a sheep, and gave silver equal to its weight as charity to the needy, which is referred to as an ‘*aqīqah* according to the tradition (*sunnah*) of the Prophet ﷺ.

1 Ḥaḍramī Shāfi‘ī, Shahāb ad-Dīn Aḥmad, *Wasīlat al-Māl fi ‘Add Manāqib al-Āl*, P. 7.

IMĀMAH OF IMĀM ḤASAN ؑ

During the *Imāmah* of Imām Ḥasan ؑ, Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was just a young child. Imām as-Sajjād ؑ saw first-hand the difficulties that his uncle, Imām Ḥasan ؑ, experienced. He saw that the unjust rulers of the time imposed restrictions on his uncle and his father, and how badly the Muslims of the time treated his uncle.

Imām as-Sajjād ؑ spent time with his uncle as a child. He observed how worshiped Allah ﷻ, and how he wept when he remembered about death, being placed in the grave, and when there would be talk of resurrection. He noticed that when he would stand for the prayers, his hands would shake out of fear, reverence of Allah ﷻ.



95 AH
713 AD

Martyrdom of Imām as-Sajjād ؑ



WISH OF IMĀM AS-SAJJĀD ﷺ

One time during his childhood, our 4th Imām, Imām Zaynul ‘Ābidīn ﷺ became very ill. Imām Husayn ﷺ came into the room that he was laying down in, hugged him and kissed him, then asked: “How are you feeling, my son? Is there anything you wish to have that I can bring for you?”

Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ responded to his father:

“I only have one wish and that is for Allah ﷻ to place me amongst those who are ever-pleased and satisfied with whatever He decrees for them.”

Hearing these beautiful words, his father hugged him and said: “You have indeed spoken words of deep knowledge (ma‘rifah). Your answer is similar to that of Prophet Ibrāhīm when he was thrown into the fire (by Namrūd), and Angel Jibrā‘īl met him and asked him if he had any wishes, to which Prophet Ibrāhīm replied: ‘Indeed I do, but not from you!’”²



STOP AND REFLECT: How were these two wishes of Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ and Prophet Ibrāhīm ﷺ similar?

Even at such a young age, the Imām ﷺ knew how to ask for a beautiful prayer (du‘ā’)!

Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ was about 12 years old when he witnessed the martyrdom (shahādah) of Imām Ḥasan ﷺ. This was the peak of Mu‘āwiyah’s power, and times were tough for the Ahlul Bayt ﷺ in Medina. His uncle’s body was shot with arrows when they tried to bury it near the grave of the Prophet ﷺ. Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ witnessed this, and he stood by Imām Ḥusayn ﷺ and helped in whatever capacity he could.

² Shaykh Ṣadūq, ‘Ilal ash-Sharā‘ī’, Pp. 23-24.

DURING THE IMĀMAH OF IMĀM ḤUSAYN ؑ: 28th Ṣafar 50 AH to 10th Muḥarram 61 AH (11 years)

Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was approximately 23 years old when he accompanied his father to Karbalā'. Until the day of 'Āshūrā', or perhaps a couple of days earlier, Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was perfectly healthy, preparing for battle alongside his brothers. He was ready to sacrifice his life and stand up to the unjust rulers of the time to save Islam. However, Allah ﷻ knew that *Imāmah* needed to be preserved through him.

It was part of a Divine plan that Imām as-Sajjād ؑ became extremely ill on the night before 'Āshūrā' and could not participate in the battle the next day. This was the way that Allah ﷻ, out of His infinite wisdom, wished to preserve the lineage of the 12 Imāms ؑ. Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was so sick that he could not even get out of the cot that he lay on in his tent.

On the day of 'Āshūrā', after the last companion and family member had given up their lives for Imām Ḥusayn ؑ, the only two adult males which remained in that camp were the two Imāms ؑ. When it came time for Imām Ḥusayn ؑ to depart to the battlefield for the last battle, he went into the tent of Imām as-Sajjād ؑ to pass on the position of *Imāmah* to him. During the battle, when Imām Ḥusayn ؑ called out for help, Imām as-Sajjād ؑ tried his best to get up so he could go to his father's assistance. He stood up while he was shaking intensely, and dragging his sword like a cane, came out of the tent. But according to some reports, his father commanded Umm Kulthūm: "Restrain him! Otherwise, there will be no one from the family of Muḥammad left on this Earth!"³

After the martyrdom of his father, the role of *Imāmah* transferred to Imām as-Sajjād ؑ at the age of 22. After the day of 'Āshūrā', the families of the Caravan (including the Banī Hāshim and companions) were taken as captives. Throughout the difficulties that the women and children of the Ahlul Bayt ؑ faced after the day of 'Āshūrā', Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was the pillar of support for all of them. In the journey to Kūfah and Shām, the Imām ؑ gave strong speeches in which he utterly humiliated the Banī Umayyah, waking up the people, and informing them about the crimes that had occurred in Karbalā'.



THE TITLE “AS-SAJJĀD”

Our fourth Imām ؑ earned a beautiful title from Allah ﷻ that he is commonly known by.

Imām Muḥammad al-Bāqir ؑ narrates:

*My father, 'Alī ibn Ḥusayn ؑ, would go into prostration (perform sajdah) whenever he remembered a favor of Allah ﷻ. He would do sajdah whenever he would recite a verse (āyah) from the book of Allah ﷻ that contained sajdah in it. Whenever Allah ﷻ would repel any evil from him that he was afraid of, or the plotting of any corrupt person, he would go into sajdah. Whenever he would finish any obligatory prayer, he would do sajdah. Whenever he was successful in reconciling two people, he would do sajdah. There was a mark of sajdah on all of the places of his body that touched the ground during the position of sajdah. Hence, he became known as: As-Sajjād.*⁴



STOP AND REFLECT: Identify some of the aspects of your life in which you can incorporate the worship of Allah ﷻ into your routine to emulate Imām as-Sajjād's worship. Remember to start with the obligatory things (the *wājibāt*)!

³ Māzindarānī, Sayyid Muḥammad Mahdī, *Ma'ālī as-Sibtayn*, Vol. 2, Pp. 20-21.

⁴ *'Ilal ash-Sharā'ī*, Vol. 1, P. 233.

Activity 2.6a: Review Questions

1. In the beginning of this lesson, we saw that the Prophet of Allah (*Rasūlullāh*) ﷺ told his companion, Jābir, the name of the 4th Imām ؑ. Recall who Jābir ibn ‘Abdullāh al-Anṣārī was. Why is this ḥadīth significant?

2. How old was Imām as-Sajjād ؑ when his grandfather, Imām ‘Alī ؑ, was martyred? Would he have been old enough to see the injustices that his grandfather faced?

3. What are the two most famous titles of Imām ‘Alī ibn Ḥusayn ؑ ? How are these two related? What is the difference between the two?

Activity 2.6b: A Personal Du‘ā’

The book, *Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah as-Sajjādiyyah*, can be found here:
www.al-islam.org/sahifa-al-kamilah-al-sajjadiyya-imam-ali-zayn-al-abidin/

Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah as-Sajjādiyyah is a collection of supplications (*du‘ās*) and whispered prayers (*munājāt*) taught by Imām as-Sajjād ؑ, and we see that the Imām begins the prayers with the praise of Allah ﷻ, followed by praise of His Messenger ﷺ, and the Ahlul Bayt ؑ.

In the following *du‘ās*, we see that the Imām ؑ often uses this similar pattern to make *du‘ā*; and it is also one of the recommended acts to start our supplications with *Bismillāh* and *Ṣalawāt*.

A translator of the *Ṣaḥīfah* says:

In the Ṣaḥīfah, we see Islamic spirituality—or that dimension of the religion of Islam which deals with the practical and lived reality of the personal relationship between human beings and God—expressed in the most universal of languages, that of the concrete and intimate yearning of the soul for completion and perfection.⁵

Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah As-Sajjādiyyah



1. What do you think this means? Show evidence from some of the *du‘ās* to back your understanding.

2. After reflecting on this statement, write a personal *du‘ā* around one specific thing you would like to ask Allah ﷻ for, perhaps using some of the words from the Ahlul Bayt ؑ as an inspiration.

5 *Translator’s introduction*. Al-Islam. (2013, January 27). Retrieved November 14, 2022, from <https://www.al-islam.org/sahifa-al-kamilah-al-sajjadiyya-imam-ali-zayn-al-abidin/translators-introduction>

2.7 Imām as-Sajjād عليه السلام in Shām

OBJECTIVES

WE WILL:

- Develop strategies to understand the dark period in the history of Shī'ahs that the 4th Imām عليه السلام had to live through.
- Analyze the speech of the Imām عليه السلام that he gave in between the *adhān* in the court of Yazīd.
- Understand the importance of the leadership style of the Imām عليه السلام, and how it was necessary for the people of his time.

FROM THE DAY OF 'ĀSHŪRĀ' TO THEIR RETURN TO MEDINA: 10th Muḥarram 61 AH to 62/63 AH

No Imām عليه السلام began his *Imāmah* in a more tragic atmosphere than the 4th Imām عليه السلام. On the first day of his *Imāmah*, he was seriously ill and was taken as a captive by the army of Yazīd in Karbalā'. His father and other family members had all sacrificed themselves and everything they had for the Truth.

Imām Zaynul 'Ābidīn عليه السلام found himself with a group of widows and orphans being forced to march from place to place. They were thrown into a prison, where the Imām spent the first portion of his *Imāmah*, cut off from the entire community. Understandably, the tragedy of Karbalā' created chaos in the Shī'ah world. The Shī'ahs were in a time of darkness, and the community was in confusion.

Imām Zaynul 'Ābidīn عليه السلام had three difficult tasks before him:

- To announce his *Imāmah* publicly
- To unite the community, and prevent Yazīd from dividing them further
- To expand the faith of the believers (*mu'minīn*) without attracting the attention of the enemies

Imām Zaynul 'Ābidīn عليه السلام, under Divine guidance, achieved all of these aims in a beautiful way. His legacy is alive even until now in the *du'ās* and *ḥadīth* we have from him today.

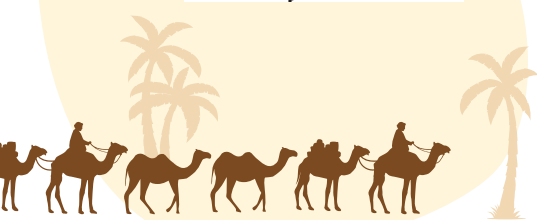
FROM KŪFAH TO SHĀM

From Kūfah, the captives were taken to Shām (Damascus). Perhaps it was on this journey that Imām as-Sajjād عليه السلام recited a supplication which eventually became known as Du'ā' #8 from *Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah As-Sajjādiyyah*, "His Prayer for Seeking Refuge from Hateful Things."

Recitation of this *du'ā'*, and other pearls of wisdom that came from the Imām's blessed tongue, would catch the attention of those around him. His supplications discussed spiritual diseases such as arrogance, jealousy, and greed. He wanted to awaken the people and help them realize that their deception was rooted in diseases of the soul.

When the caravan reached an area near Shām, the army made them stop. Yazīd wanted to decorate the city to show their joy in the 'victory' over the grandson of the Prophet of Allah ﷺ. When the city was fully decorated, the Ahlul Bayt عليه السلام were paraded through the streets of Shām, and people celebrated the death of Imām Ḥusayn عليه السلام.

Unfortunately, the Banī Umayyah had spread so much propaganda and false rumors that the people were convinced that these captives were blameworthy and deserved being prisoners.





STOP AND REFLECT: List three ways in which news spreads in our day and age; and then list the ways in which misinformation can be spread.

One elderly man approached Imām as-Sajjād ؑ and unknowingly said to him: “All praise is for Allah ﷻ who destroyed you and granted the governor power over you.”

The Imām ؑ knew that this man had been deceived by the propaganda and people around him, so the Imām ؑ asked him: “Respected elder, have you read the Qur’ān?”

The man answered: “Yes, of course I have!”

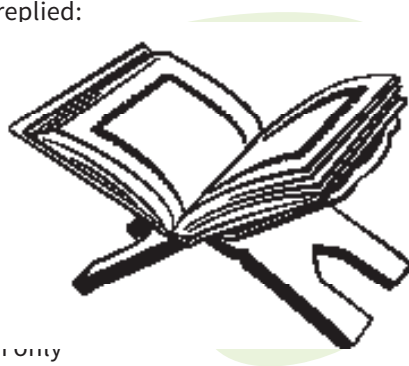
The Imām ؑ continued: “Have you read the verse that says: ‘Say: I do not ask from you any reward for it except love of my close ones;’ and the verse which says: ‘And give the [Prophet’s] relatives their [due] right;’ and the verse that says: ‘Know that whatever thing you may come by, a fifth of it is for Allah and the Messenger, and for the relatives [of the Prophet].’”

The elderly Syrian faintly replied:
“Yes, I have read all of the

The Imām ؑ then told him: “I swear by Allah that we are the relatives and kinsfolk referred to in all of these verses. Shaykh¹, have you read these words of Allah, the exalted: ‘Allah only desires to keep away impurity from you, O Household (of the Prophet), and purify you with a thorough purification?’”²

Again, the man answered: “Yes.”

The Imām ؑ continued: “We are the Household (of the Prophet) whom Allah favored with this Verse of Purification.”



By this point, the elderly man was shaking. *O how I wish that the earth had swallowed me up before I said my words*, he thought to himself. He asked the Imām ؑ: “By Allah, are you really those people?”

“I swear by our grandfather, the Prophet of Allah (Rasūlullāh), that we are—without any doubt,” replied the Imām ؑ.

Hearing the Imām’s ؑ reply, the man fell to his knees and began kissing Imām as-Sajjād’s hands. With tears in his eyes, he declared: “I dissociate myself before Allah from those who killed you!”

He asked the Imām ؑ for forgiveness, and the Imām ؑ immediately forgave the man.³

It was through his manners (*akhlāq*) and reminders to the people that the Imām ؑ managed to bring them out of their heedlessness (*ghaflah*), and awaken them, and help them realize who they were.



STOP AND REFLECT: Is implementing good treatment of others (*adab*) part of your responsibility when you are trying to advise them? Are there times in which you would need to dissociate yourself from others instead of advising them?

Even though he was taken through the city in chains, Imām as-Sajjād ؑ took every opportunity to remind the people about the status of the Ahlul Bayt ؑ. Whenever he was given a chance, he would speak bravely and eloquently. He demonstrated courageousness and standing up to the oppressors through dissociation with them. He continued to remind the people of justice, and encouraged them to worship Allah ﷻ in the right way. This was his duty as the Imām, because he knew what was right and what his responsibilities were.

1 Shaykh in this instance is referring to an elderly man as this was the norm in those days.

2 Noble Qur’ān, Sūrah al-Aḥzāb (33), Verse 33.

3 Sayyid Ibn Ṭawūs, *Al-Luhūf*, P. 177.

SPEECH IN THE COURT OF YAZĪD

Perhaps one of the most powerful speeches given by Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was in the court of Yazīd in Shām. Yazīd had invited so many people to his palace, including important nobles, to celebrate his victory over the Ahlul Bayt ؑ. Once the court was full of people, he ordered a speaker to ascend the pulpit and curse Imām ‘Alī ؑ and the Ahlul Bayt ؑ, and praise Mu‘āwiyah and Yazīd. As the man was spouting these lies, Imām as-Sajjād ؑ interrupted him and said: “Woe unto you! You have traded the pleasure of the creation for the wrath of the Creator, so take your place in the fire of Hell!”

The Imām ؑ then turned to Yazīd and asked for permission to sit on some of the pieces of wood, and deliver a speech that would bring rewards for everyone present. Those in attendance were shocked at this prisoner who was also sick, and how he dared to interrupt the gathering. Of course, Yazīd refused his request to speak, but the people insisted.

STOP AND REFLECT: Why do you think the Imām said he wanted to sit on the pieces of wood instead of referring to it as a minbar?

The people were confused and asked Yazīd: “What can this sick man do to you?” They did not know who the Imām ؑ was. The people kept pressuring Yazīd, so he had no choice but to allow the Imām ؑ to deliver his talk.

The Imām ؑ sat on the pile of woods, indicating that even a minbar can lose its function if it is not used properly in the way of obedience of the chosen ones of Allah (under the *wilāyah*), and began speaking and delivering one of the most eloquent speeches in all of history: one that moved the entire crowd to tears. The Imām ؑ began by introducing himself and his family, and reminding the people that the Ahlul Bayt ؑ were sent as Divine guides to all of humanity.

He said: “Whoever recognizes me, knows me; but whoever does not recognize me, let me introduce myself and the family to which I belong...” Then he continued in this manner: describing himself, his grandfathers the Prophet of Allah ﷺ and Imām ‘Alī ؑ, and then finally mentioning the tragedy of Karbalā’ until the people were weeping uncontrollably.

Yazīd was sweating in his seat, thinking that the people would revolt against him. After all, the Imām ؑ explained to the Syrians all about himself and his family, igniting a cultural revolution. Yazīd quickly ordered the *mu’adhin* to recite the *adhān* so as to distract the people.⁴

The *mu’adhin* right away began to recite: “Allāhu Akbar, Allāhu Akbar!”

The Imām ؑ turned to him and said: “You have made great the One Who cannot be measured or felt by senses; and there is nothing greater than Allah ﷻ.”

The *mu’adhin* continued: “Ashhadu an-lā ilāha illallāh!”

The Imām ؑ then said: “My hair, skin, flesh, blood, brain, and bones bear witness that there is no god except Allah ﷻ.”

The *mu’adhin* went on: “Ashhadu anna Muḥammadan Rasūlullāh!”

At this point, the Imām ؑ turned to Yazīd and asked him: “O Yazīd, is Muḥammad your grandfather or mine? If you say that he is yours, then you are a liar; and if you say that he is mine, then why did you kill his family?”⁵

Yazīd was speechless and dumbfounded. The Imām’s grandfather was the Prophet of Allah ﷺ, whereas Yazīd’s grandfather was Abū Sufyān, the enemy of the Prophet ﷺ and Allah ﷻ.

STOP AND REFLECT: Why do you think the Imām ؑ focused his speech on identifying who he was? What was the effect of this?

The Imām’s speech had a massive effect on the Syrians. They left the gathering feeling they had been misled by the Banī Umayyah, and guilty about their transgressions. They began spreading the word about the Umayyad propaganda, and people’s attitudes toward Yazīd quickly began to change and became more negative.

4 ‘Allāmah Majlisī, *Biḥār al-Anwār*, Vol. 45, P. 138.

5 Al-Qummī, Shaykh ‘Abbās, *Nafas al-Mahmūm*, P. 262.

THE AHLUL BAYT ﷺ ARE FINALLY FREED

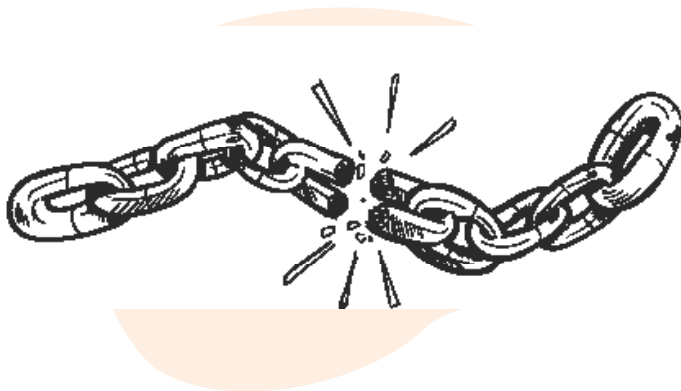
Soon, the Syrians became extremely restless and resentful toward Yazīd, so he knew that he had to amend the situation right away. Therefore, he summoned Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ and apologized to him so that the people would think that Yazīd was not at fault. He then shifted the blame for Imām Ḥusayn's death to Ibn Ziyād⁶ and said: "May Allah curse Ibn Ziyād! I swear by Allah that if I had been with Ḥusayn, he never would have asked me for a favor without me granting it to him! I would have protected him from death with all of my power, even if I had to sacrifice my own children!"⁷ He then told the Imām ﷺ that he could ask for anything he wanted. The Imām ﷺ knew that his apology was insincere and he was just trying to save face and himself, so he turned away and did not answer him.

Again, Yazīd called Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ and told him to ask for whatever he wanted. So, the Imām ﷺ replied: "I want my father's head back, and I want you to return to us whatever you plundered. If you want to kill me, then send someone to take my family back to Medina."

Yazīd bowed his head and thought about the Imām's requests. Then, he raised his head up and replied: "As for the face of your father, you will never see it. As for what was taken from you, it will be brought back to you. As for the women, no one will return with them except you; and as for you, I will not kill you."⁸

Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ and his family demanded that the heads be given back, and since Yazīd was at a loss due to the pressures around him, he realized that he had no choice left and had to comply with the Imām's request.

Yazīd ordered Nu'mān ibn Bashīr to escort Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ and the women back to Medina. According to some reports, the women asked Nu'mān to take them first to Karbalā' so they could perform the visitation (*ziyārah*) of Imām Ḥusayn ﷺ and the martyrs of Karbalā'. They remained there to mourn for three days before finally heading back to their hometown of Medina.



THE LEADERSHIP STYLE OF THE IMĀM ﷺ

Sorrow and grief can often succeed in bringing people together. At the time of a tragedy, everyone unites to share the sorrow, and shoulder the resulting responsibilities. Imām Zaynul 'Ābidīn ﷺ used this method to unite the community when he was freed from prison.

It is said that he continued to weep until his eyes became very weak. Whenever he would take a cup to drink some water, the water would become mixed with his tears.⁹ When he asked about this, he replied:

"Why should I not cry, when my father was denied water which was free for the beasts and animals even to drink?"¹⁰



The Imām ﷺ lived during a period of brutal caliphs, each one trying to outdo the previous one in their brutality to the Ahlul Bayt ﷺ. Imām as-Sajjād ﷺ used his tears and supplications to Allah ﷻ in order to teach his followers, especially since the caliphs limited him from preaching.

The Imām ﷺ was martyred at the age of 57, on the 25th of Muharram in the year 95 AH. He was poisoned by the caliph, Walīd ibn 'Abdul Malik, who was instigated to commit this crime by his brother, Hishām. When the Imām ﷺ passed away the sounds of crying and wailing were heard across the city of Medina. Men and women, young and old, free ones and the slaves—everyone was in a state of mourning. Pious people and sinners alike attended his funeral. He was laid to rest in the Baqī' Cemetery, next to his uncle Imām Ḥasan ﷺ.

6 Ibn al-Jawzī, Sibṭ, *Tazkirat al-Khawāṣṣ*, Pp. 261 and 265.

7 Ṭabarī, Muḥammad ibn Jarīr, *Tārīkh aṭ-Ṭabarī*, Vol. 5, P. 506.

8 *Al-Luhūf*, Vol. 1, P. 174.

9 *Al-Luhūf*, Vol.1, P. 121.

10 *Biḥār al-Anwār*, Vol. 45, P. 149.

Activity 2.7a: Comic Strip

Use the space below to illustrate one of the following events mentioned in this lesson:

- 1. Conversation with the elderly man in Damascus.
- 2. The speech of the Imām (عليه السلام) in the courtyard of Yazīd.
- 3. Imām as-Sajjād's conversation with Yazīd when the Ahlul Bayt (عليهم السلام) were freed.

Activity 2.7b: Worksheet

In this lesson, we briefly referenced the speech that Imām Zaynul ‘Ābidīn ؑ made in the court of Yazīd. Here is an extended version of this speech:

O people! We have been bestowed six qualities, and seven merits by Allah ﷻ. The six qualities we have are: Knowledge, forbearance, munificence, eloquence, valor, and friendship in the hearts of the believers.

While our (seven) merits are: The Prophet in Authority is from amongst us; the truthful one (Imām ‘Alī) is from amongst us; the one who flies (Ja’far aṭ-Ṭayyār) is from amongst us; the Lion of Allah and that of His Prophet (Imām ‘Alī) is from amongst us; and the two youth (Imāms Ḥasan and Ḥusayn) of this nation are also from amongst us. Those who know me, know me; and those who do not know me, I will reveal my pedigree and ancestry for them until they recognize me.

O people! I am the son of Mecca and Minā. I am the son of Zamzam and Ṣafā.

I am the son of the one who was taken up to Sidrat al-Muntahā. I am the son of the one ‘who was bestowed revelation by the Almighty, what He did reveal.’¹¹ I am the son of Muḥammad, the Chosen One!

I am the son of the person who fought against the enemies with two swords. He emigrated twice, pledged allegiance twice (to the Prophet), and prayed in the two qiblahs. I am the son of ‘Alī, the Approved One.

I am the son of Fātimah az-Zahrā’.

I am the son of Ḥusayn, the one killed in Karbalā’. [It is said that the Imām became emotional at this time] I am the son of the one who was smeared in blood and sand. I am the son of the one who was lamented upon by the Spirit in the darkness of the night. I am the son of the one who was mourned by the birds.¹²

11 See Noble Qur’ān, Sūrah an-Najm (53), Verses 1-18 which describe this miraculous event.

12 *Biḥār al-Anwār*, Vol. 45, P. 138.

1. Let us take apart some of the lessons in this speech. What could the aim of the Imām ﷺ be in praising the Ahlul Bayt ﷺ so much?

[illegible]

2. Recall how we have talked about self-confidence and arrogance. How can we explain that this speech is not a show of arrogance from the Imām ﷺ?

[illegible]

3. Why did Yazīd consider it necessary to stop the speech here, when the Imām ﷺ had just begun describing his family?

[illegible]

4. Do you think there were any people who were not affected by this speech? If so, then why?

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

2.8 Imām ‘Alī as-Sajjād ؑ: Reforming Hearts

OBJECTIVES

WE WILL:

- Describe the atmosphere in Medina when Imām as-Sajjād ؑ returned after the martyrdom (*shahādah*) of his father, Imām Ḥusayn ؑ.
- Analyze the sociopolitical purposes behind Imām as-Sajjād’s supplications (*du‘ās*).
- Outline ways in which the Imām ؑ remained steadfast and patient despite the multiple unjust rulers of his time.
- Describe the legacy of Imām as-Sajjād ؑ.

RETURN TO MEDINA UNTIL HIS OWN MARTYRDOM: 2nd Rabī‘ al-Awwal 62 AH to 25th Muḥarram 95 AH

When Imām as-Sajjād ؑ and the caravan approached Medina, he set up a tent for the women. Then, the Imām ؑ turned to a man named Bashīr ibn Hadhlam, whose father was a famous poet, and asked him to enter Medina and announce the death of Imām Ḥusayn ؑ ahead of the caravan. Bashīr went near the Masjid an-Nabī where he loudly cried out:

*O people of Medina! May you never stay therein!
Ḥusayn was killed, so let the tears now rain,
His body is in Karbalā’, all blood-stained!
While his head is on a spear, for all displayed.*

Hearing this, the people began to cry out loudly and gathered around Bashīr, asking him for more information. He announced: “Here is ‘Alī ibn Ḥusayn, accompanied by his aunts and sisters; they have all returned to you. I am his messenger to inform you about where he is.”¹

The people went out to welcome the Imām ؑ and his caravan, all the while crying and wailing, offering their condolences.

IMĀM AS-SAJJĀD’S STRUGGLES IN MEDINA

Even though our Imāms ؑ were present, there were always those who sought to keep power for themselves and away from the Imāms ؑ, because they knew that they would not get special privileges if the Imāms ؑ lead the people with justice. Although people commonly think that Imām as-Sajjād’s problems ended when he returned to Medina, the city of his grandfather, the era of oppression continued until his own martyrdom.

There were many people in the city who abandoned the Imām ؑ out of fear of being associated with him, and out of a desire to be closer to the governing leadership. Even some of the people who used to love the Imām ؑ before he went to Karbalā’ were now hiding their love for him. During this time, the Imām ؑ said: “In Mecca and Medina, there are not even 20 people who love us, the Ahlul Bayt.”²

According to some scholars and historical narrations, for some years after returning to Medina, Imām as-Sajjād ؑ used to live in a black tent in the desert outside of the city. He did this because he did not want to be in contact with the people who had been disloyal to him. From the desert, the Imām ؑ would secretly go to perform the visitation (*ziyārah*) of his father and grandfather in Iraq. Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was not even allowed in the Prophet’s Masjid and would sit outside by the shoes.

¹ Sayyid Ibn Ṭāwūs, *Al-Luhūf*, P. 115.

² Ibn Abil Ḥadīd, *Sharḥ Nahj al-Balāghah*, Vol. 4, P. 104.

IMĀM AS-SAJJĀD'S SUPPLICATIONS (DU'ĀS)

One of the primary methods that Imām as-Sajjād ؑ used to bring people to the path of true Islam was to spread the pure teachings in the form of supplications (*du'ās*), whispered prayers, and advice.

For example, in a manner that would not be seen as political, he would talk about the concept of Imamate (*Imāmah*). He introduced *Imāmah* as a fundamental Islamic belief that all Muslims will be questioned about in their graves.

This made people think: *Who really are the Imāms ؑ in our time? Can the Banū Umayyah be the true and Divinely-appointed Imāms?!* Similarly the famous compilation of his supplications and whispered prayers in the book entitled, *Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah as-Sajjādiyyah*, is full of Islamic teachings with regards to beliefs, culture, society, politics, as well as practical rulings—all passed on through the unique method of supplications. This book is one of the greatest treasures that we have today.

There are supplications for all different topics and issues, such as the rights of parents, children, and neighbors; for when you are in a difficult situation, have a worrisome task, engulfed in sorrows, or sickness. These *du'ās* can help us in every situation in our lives, and shape our hearts as well. It was through these *du'ās* that Imām as-Sajjād ؑ would preach to and teach the people. His supplications were full of important messages about ethics and morals (*akhlāq*), courage, knowledge, Monotheism (*Tawḥīd*), and so much more.



STOP AND REFLECT: How can prayers and supplications change and refine the state of people's hearts?

The governor at the time could not stop him because he was reciting supplications, but through these powerful *du'ās*, he was able to spread the teachings of Islam and slowly shape the hearts of the people. This was how he laid the foundations that allowed the people to start understanding Islam better, and become students of the Imāms ؑ after him, like Imām al-Bāqir ؑ and Imām aṣ-Ṣādiq ؑ.

SPREADING AWARENESS OF 'ĀSHŪRĀ'

The Imām ؑ would also do everything in his power to educate the people about the events of Karbalā'. He knew that the key to keeping Islam alive was to remind others about the sacrifice of Imām Ḥusayn ؑ and the oppression that he and his family underwent. For example, whenever he would pass through the meat market and saw a butcher ready to slaughter an animal, he would ask them: "What are you doing?"

The butcher would reply: "I am about to slaughter this animal."

The Imām ؑ would tell them: "Make sure you give it some water! My father was slaughtered without any water!"³

Hearing this, people would become intrigued and want to know more about what had transpired.





STOP AND REFLECT: Why is reminding people about Karbalā' the key to keeping Islam alive?

The caliphate at that time had made it forbidden (*ḥarām*) to mourn and commemorate the sacrifice of Imām Ḥusayn ؑ, so the 4th Imām ؑ would hold secret gatherings (*majālis*) during the time of Ḥajj—underground and in abandoned locations. After seven years, due to the political disputes that were happening, the caliphs shifted their focus away from him.

After Imām as-Sajjād ؑ returned to Medina and word spread about the events of Karbalā', many people were outraged at Yazīd's blatant oppression. Rebellions began springing up all over the Muslim world, as people attempted to oust Yazīd out of power.

REBELLION IN MEDINA

When the news about Imām Ḥusayn's martyrdom (*shahādah*) reached the people of Medina, they were infuriated. As a result, the governor of Medina decided to send some nobles to Shām to meet with Yazīd. He was hoping that Yazīd would bribe them to calm them down. However, when they saw Yazīd up close—his drinking, gambling, and other bad habits—they returned to Medina even more upset. They began telling

everyone about Yazīd's un-Islamic behavior, and that he was completely unfit to be the leader of the Muslims. Soon after, a rebellion broke out, and the Umayyads—the followers of Yazīd—were kicked out of Medina.

When Yazīd heard about this, he sent an army to Medina to squash the rebellion. This happened almost three years after the tragedy of Karbalā'. His army surrounded the city, giving the people no choice except to surrender. After this, Yazīd's army entered the city and wreaked havoc, slaughtering and harming thousands of innocent and pious people. This horrible incident came to be known as the 'Tragedy of Ḥarrah.'

During this tragedy, Yazīd had given clear instructions to his commander not to harm Imām as-Sajjād ؑ or his family. Thus, the Imām's home actually became a safe haven, and many people were given shelter there. According to narrations, he housed more than 400 people during this time, many of whom had previously mistreated his family, such as Marwān ibn al-Ḥakam.



STOP AND REFLECT: Which good traits of morals and etiquettes (*akhlāq*) is the Imām ؑ demonstrating by giving shelter to those who hurt his family before? Can this action of the Imām ؑ be counted as a form of charity?

THE TAWWĀBĪN

(Those who were Penitents/Repenters)

Another notable rebellion that occurred as a result of the tragedy of Karbalā' was that of the Tawwābīn. They were the same individuals who gave their allegiance (*bay'ah*) to Muslim ibn 'Aqīl when he first came to Kūfah, but then they turned their backs on him. Immediately after the day of 'Āshūrā', they regretted their actions and wanted to atone for their mistake, hence their title: "The Tawwābīn" which means "those who repent." The Tawwābīn were led by a man named Sulaymān ibn Ṣurad al-Khuzā'i, and they rose up in the year 65 AH seeking revenge for Imām Ḥusayn (عليه السلام), but they were quickly suppressed and killed.

MUKHTĀR ATH-THAQAFĪ

Perhaps the most famous uprising was that of Mukhtār ibn Abī 'Ubayd ath-Thaqafī. Mukhtār was imprisoned before the battle of Karbalā', and therefore on the day of 'Āshūrā' he was not able to be with Imām Ḥusayn (عليه السلام). When he was released from prison, he began a mission to seek revenge for what had transpired on the plains of Karbalā'. Although it is not fully clear whether Imām as-Sajjād (عليه السلام) supported Mukhtār's movement or not, it has been established that he did not oppose it. He is recorded to have said: "May Allah reward Mukhtār with goodness,"⁴ when Mukhtār killed 'Ubaydullāh ibn Ziyād and 'Umar ibn Sa'd.

Mukhtār's uprising began in 66 AH, and his army managed to kill many of the enemies, such as Ḥarmalah, Shimr, and 'Umar ibn Sa'd. They also overthrew and killed Ibn Ziyād, the governor of Kūfah, and Mukhtār then took over and became the governor there. He only ruled for a little over a year, after which he was overthrown and killed by the army of Muṣ'ab ibn Zubayr.

THE STATE OF THE CALIPHATE (KHILĀFAH)

Yazīd was only the caliph (*khalifah*) for about three years. He died in the year 64 AH, after which his son, Mu'āwiyah ibn Yazīd, was appointed to the position. This man though was a pious person. He saw the oppressions that his father had caused to the family of the Ahlul Bayt (عليه السلام), so after 40 days he abdicated (relinquished) the caliphate and disapproved of his father and grandfather's opposition of Imām 'Alī (عليه السلام) and his children.

Now, the Umayyads were unsure about who the new caliph should be. Eventually, the caliphate fell into the hands of Marwān ibn Ḥakam. Marwān had previously been the governor of Medina, and he was the one who tried to force Walīd to get the allegiance (*bay'ah*) from Imām Ḥusayn (عليه السلام). Marwān was the ruler for 9 months, until he was assassinated in 65 AH. Then, his son, 'Abdul Malik ibn Marwān, became the caliph.

THE KHILĀFAH OF 'ABD AL-MALIK IBN MARWĀN

One of the darkest periods in the history of Islam was during the rulership of 'Abdul Malik ibn Marwān, which coincided with 21 years of Imām as-Sajjād's (عليه السلام) *Imāmah*. Prior to becoming the caliph, 'Abdul Malik was known to be a pious person in Medina because he would spend a lot of time worshipping.

According to several narrations, he was reciting the Qur'ān when he received the news about his father's death. Upon hearing this, he promptly closed the Qur'ān and said to this noble Book: "This is where you and I part ways!"



STOP AND REFLECT: How can a change in circumstances change the relationship that people have with Allah (ﷻ)?

His actions demonstrate how he truly did separate himself from the Qur'ān. He was a vicious oppressor whose heart became hard due to his horrible actions. He himself admitted: "I have changed so much to the point that if I do good actions, I do not become happy; and if I commit evil actions, I do not become upset."⁵

⁴ 'Allāmah Majlisī, *Bihār al-Anwār*, Vol. 45, P. 385.

⁵ Ibn Athīr, *Al-Kāmil fī at-Tārikh*, Vol. 4, P. 521.

THE KHILĀFAH OF WALĪD IBN ‘ABDUL MALIK

After the death of ‘Abdul Malik, his son Walīd became the next caliph. He felt that as long as Imām as-Sajjād ؑ was alive, his rulership was not safe because the people loved the Imām ؑ too much. Therefore, he decided to assassinate the Imām ؑ by ordering the governor of Medina to poison him.

After drinking the poison, Imām as-Sajjād ؑ suffered severe pain and was bedridden for a few days. During this time, he kept praying to Allah ﷻ, and whenever people came to visit him, he would praise Allah ﷻ and thank Him for granting him martyrdom.

Imām as-Sajjād ؑ finally left this world on the 25th of Muḥarram, in the year 95 AH. Prior to his martyrdom, he made it clear to the people that his son, Imām Muḥammad al-Bāqir ؑ, would be the Imām after him.⁶

THE LEGACY OF IMĀM AS-SAJJĀD ؑ

Imām as-Sajjād ؑ left behind many beautiful supplications (*du‘ās*) and lessons for us in:

- *Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah as-Sajjādiyyah*
(Collection of Supplications of Imām as-Sajjād)
- *Risālat al-Ḥuqūq*
(Treaties of Rights)
- *Al-Munājāt al-Khamsah ‘Asharah*
(The 15 Whispered Prayers).



After the death of Imām Ḥusayn ؑ, the circumstances remained very difficult for Imām as-Sajjād ؑ. We can use the lessons of his steadfastness and patience to think about different responsibilities that we have to fulfill in our lives.

We know for a fact that he made the best decision in every situation because the Imāms ؑ are *nūrun wāḥid*—meaning that they are all from the same light, and each one of them is immaculate. In our lives, we must always try our best to be tactful about the decisions that we have to make in order to ensure that they align with the teachings of the Ahlul Bayt ؑ.

⁶ Shaykh Ṣadūq, *Al-Amālī*, Vol. 1, P. 435.

Activity 2.8a: A Timeline of Imāmah

In the timeline below, add in the events that happened [during the life-time of Imām as-Sajjād ؑ] in the highlighted year.

Highlighted Year	Event
38 AH	
50 AH	
61 AH	
63 AH	
64 AH	
65 AH	
86 AH	
95 AH	

Activity 2.8b: Analyze a Supplication (Du‘ā’) from *Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah as-Sajjādiyyah*

Sayyid Husayn M. Ja‘farī, a translator of *Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah as-Sajjādiyyah*, answers the question: “Why does Imām as-Sajjād ؑ pray for forgiveness of sins when he is inerrant (free from committing any sins)?”

He writes that:

The original Arabic words استغفار and توبة (istighfār and tawbah) can be translated as ‘seeking forgiveness’ and ‘repentance,’ but they convey meanings far broader than the English terms, both of which are connected with a sentimental and moralistic sense of guilt.

When the Prophet ﷺ or Imām Zaynul ‘Ābidīn ؑ ask Allah ﷻ for forgiveness, they are perfectly sincere in this request, but it does not imply that they have any sins, rather they are asking forgiveness for not being able to truly thank Allah ﷻ how He deserves.⁷

With the lens above, examine the Whispered Prayer (*Munājāt*) #1 toward the end of *Aṣ-Ṣaḥīfah as-Sajjādiyyah* which is referred to as the ‘Whispered Prayer of the Repenters’ (*Munājāt at-Tā‘ibīn*). Read through the entire prayer, and then answer the following questions:

1. Why do you think Imām Zaynul ‘Ābidīn ؑ prays for forgiveness in so many of his supplications and prayers (*du‘ās* and *munājāt*)?

2. What can we learn from this whispered prayer?

⁷ Translator’s Foreword: <https://www.al-islam.org/sahifa-al-kamilah-al-sajjadiyya-imam-ali-zayn-al-abidin/translators-introduction>

3. Annotate this *munājāt* based on your reflections when you read each line or section. Do not share your reflections with others. For example, you may reflect on some of the sins in your life that you are reminded of.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are approximately 20 lines visible. The paper has a slight shadow on the right side, suggesting it's resting on a surface.

4. When you reach the end of this whispered prayer which details Allah's forgiving attributes, reflect on how each attribute is connected with forgiveness and repentance. Write your reflections here.

[illegible]

Activity 4.3a: Scenarios

DIRECTIONS: Read the following scenarios, then write down why the decision might be difficult for the person to uphold, and what they should do in that situation. Then, discuss it with the class.

- 1. Mujtaba and his friend, Zayn, go bike riding. Zayn breaks his bike, and tells Mujtaba not to tell their other friends until it is fixed. The next day, Mujtaba and his other friends go out bike riding, and they ask why Zayn did not join them. What should Mujtaba say?

- 2. Asiyah’s uncle asks her if she can help him by babysitting his daughter. Asiyah is about to leave her friend’s house to go to her uncle’s house, but her friends tell her to stay longer. What should Asiyah do?

- 3. Sarah is supposed to check on her friend’s plants while she is away, but she gets busy with other things and remembers very late to check on them. What should she do?

- 4. Husayn tells his mom that if he is allowed to stay home and not go shopping with her, then he will do his chores. However, as soon as she leaves, he realizes that his favorite show is coming on TV. What should Husayn do?

Activity 4.3b: Skits

DIRECTIONS: Create a skit where a person has to decide whether to break another person’s trust or promise, or do the right thing using the examples above, or your own examples. After your skit, explain why the decision was difficult for the person in the skit, and how they overcame it.

Similarly, entertainment can fulfill the purpose of us getting closer to Allah ﷻ if the following conditions are met: **(i)** We have the right intention of it being a means toward a greater end; **(ii)** Whatever we are doing or watching in terms of entertainment is permissible (*ḥalāl*), and does not prevent us from performing our obligations and responsibilities; and **(iii)** It is done in moderation (not in extreme).

Imām al-Kāẓim ؑ said: “The time spent in pursuing legitimate (*ḥalāl*) pleasures helps someone with the other aspects of life (including worship).”³

Useful entertainment can help us rest and rejuvenate to perform more worship, or fulfill our other responsibilities. It can help us get closer to other believers, for example, when we spend time with our family or friends. Taking a break can also be a way of relaxing our mind and body after a long day of work.



STOP AND REFLECT: What useful types of entertainment do you partake in? How does it help you?

TYPES OF ENTERTAINMENT

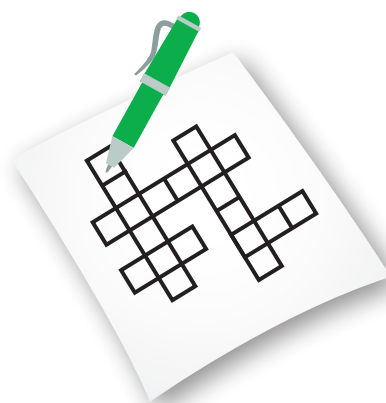
Entertainment comes in different forms, and people have their own tastes and preferences. One way of breaking down entertainment is into various categories of mental, physical, social, and media.

MENTAL ENTERTAINMENT

One form of entertainment is mental entertainment, or fun activities that use our mind such as puzzles, crosswords, trivia competitions, and so on. Some types of reading can also get us to think and reflect in a positive way. Mental entertainment can help strengthen our intellect, which can become very useful in all areas of life. Sometimes however, mental challenges involve learning useless trivia. At other times, mental entertainment can involve engaging in something forbidden, such as games which involve gambling or betting, so we must be careful not to partake in such kinds of things.

PHYSICAL ACTIVITIES

Islam places great importance on physical activities and remaining fit. In fact, one of the principles for strengthening our faith (*īmān*) is to exercise and remain healthy. We have many examples of the Prophet ﷺ and his Ahlul Bayt ؑ participating in different sports and physical activities. However, there are certain physical activities that may not be allowed for us if they could be harmful to our body or health. As well, some sports (such as contact sports that involve touching) should not be done with anyone with whom such physical contact is not permitted. If you have gym class in school in which they engage in dancing, inappropriate gender mixing, or other forbidden activities, then you can get a note to excuse you out of these things.



3 *Biḥār al-Anwār*, Vol. 75, P. 321.

MEDIA LITERACY

Media literacy in the context of what we are learning is using a set of tools to think critically about the information that is presented to us. You may have learned some of these things in school, such as when you were looking for reliable sources for a project you were researching. In an Islamic context, we want to make sure that we are seeking information correctly. Not all information that we find will be relevant or useful for us. There are some things we are better off not knowing! As well, how we go about seeking knowledge is also very important, as is what we do with it.

BE SELECTIVE ABOUT WHAT NEWS WE WATCH

When it comes to watching the news, we should think about who is presenting the information to us, and why they are saying the things that they are. An example that is quite obvious is Fox News. Many people know them to have a strong bias toward their own viewpoints or opinions of the world, but sometimes the problems can be less obvious. Occasionally, we might notice that a news station agrees with some things we believe in, but that does not mean they will always be right.



THINK, PAIR, SHARE

1. What are some examples of news shows or stations that say some good things, but also relay certain items which we as Muslims disagree with?
2. What is the reason why news organizations present information?

Some shows that we watch might have various opinions we agree with, but then mix them with certain things which we cannot concur with. For example, they might say that women not being allowed to have an education is a bad thing, but they may also refer to women who wear ḥijāb as being oppressed. They might also side with certain Muslim countries because it benefits them, while turning a blind eye to the injustices that are carried out in those countries. They might also paint other countries in an extremely negative light without ever highlighting their accomplishments. In pretty much every case, they are just looking to get high ratings and appeal to people.

When you are watching the news, you should avoid information overload. If you watch a news channel for a while or read many articles, you might notice the same stories or perspectives being repeated. We should avoid occupying our minds with unnecessary information that can prevent us from thinking clearly. News stations invest large amounts of money in trying to see what will get more people to watch their broadcasts. They are also funded by people who want to promote their own views of the world.

It is good to stay informed about what is happening in the world, but it is more important to be confident in your values, and what you know about the world before you listen to the news. For example, if we watch news about Palestine, we should be thinking about the bigger picture and what the real story must be. Over time, you will notice that the stories about Palestine from some news channels or websites always tend to present Palestinians in a negative light.



5. Author of Article 2: _____

Google the author. What did you find out about them?

6. Summarize what the article says about the topic.

7. Compare and contrast the two articles. What are the similarities and differences between what they are saying about the topic?

8. List the resources you used below.
